dwelling constantly on it, even ordering that all propagation be in line with it (‘this should be propagated in the proper manner among pupils in accordance with what is ancient usage’). This implies the emperor’s belief that traditional values and usage, which comprised ‘porana pakiti’, had been forgotten. From first to last, the manner in which the decree was drafted would have explicitly reminded those who read it that they had no choice in the matter of following ancient tradition, the last line firmly decreeing, ‘thus orders the Beloved of the Gods’.

The inclusion of the emperor’s orders, or conversely the act of editing them out, shows how a more or less identical message can acquire varied meanings when inscribed in different locations. It is a reasonable assumption that this second message which, in the cluster in Chitradurga, would have been viewed as loosely moral and rooted in tradition, would in other places, sandwiched between stern imperial orders, have been seen and possibly resented as authoritarian. So, while Ashoka may well have seen his mission as being personal and moral, the end result of his constant invocation of Buddhism in the form of orders to and by administrative officials may have been considered by many as an extension into their sacred space of the laws of the land.

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If the emperor’s first message and its resonance across large parts of India depended on specifically how his words came to be engraved at each particular location, the encounters of his mission with the cultures and practices of people in varying terrains will also have differed considerably. Of the large number of texts that have survived of this message, none were found located at or near the large cities of the Mauryan realm. Pataliputra, Vidisha, Ujjayini, and Taxila are among those that have figured in Ashoka’s life, and which we know already as being commercially and politically important. There were many others cities as well, such as Sopara, Sannathi,